Software licences: requesting and activating

Article KB0010063 | Owner: Application Support | Subcategory: Licence activation | Applies to: Windows 11 (23H2/24H2) on Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840, macOS 14/15 on MacBook Pro/Air, Adobe Creative Cloud suite, Microsoft 365 apps (Outlook, Teams, OneDrive, SharePoint), Other line-of-business applications managed through Application Support

Summary

This article guides Acme Global employees and service-desk agents through the process of requesting, assigning, and activating software licences for applications such as Adobe Creative Cloud, Microsoft 365, and other licensed tools. It outlines the self-service steps users can take to request a licence via the Company Portal, the agent workflow for approving or assigning licences in the appropriate admin consoles, and how to verify successful activation before closing the ticket.

Symptoms

- "Your licence has expired" message when launching the application
- Application prompts for a product key or licence key
- "Adobe licence not assigned" or similar licence-not-found error
- Software opens in trial mode with limited functionality
- Error code 0x80070005 (access denied) when trying to activate

Common causes

- Licence not yet assigned to the user's Entra ID account in the relevant admin console
- Existing licence has reached its expiration date and requires renewal
- Manager approval pending for a new licence request
- Device is offline or unable to reach the licence validation service (e.g., VPN not connected)
- Corrupted local licence cache or stale credentials

Initial Checks

Before proceeding with a licence request, verify that the device has network connectivity and that the user is signed in with their Acme Global credentials. Ensure the Company Portal app is installed and up to date, as it is the gateway for self-service licence requests. Confirm that the application exhibiting the issue is the one for which a licence is needed (e.g., Adobe Photoshop, Microsoft Project).

Self-Help Procedure: Request and Activate a Licence

Follow these steps to request a licence through the Company Portal and activate it on your device. The process works for both Windows and macOS devices managed by Intune. If you encounter any errors, note the exact message and contact the IT Service Desk.

1. Open the Company Portal app from the Start menu (Windows) or Applications folder (macOS).
2. Sign in with your Acme Global email address and password; approve the MFA push notification in Microsoft Authenticator.
3. Navigate to the "Apps" tab and locate the software you need (e.g., "Adobe Acrobat Pro DC").
4. Select the app and click "Request licence". A form will appear asking for a brief justification; fill it out and submit.
5. After submission, you will receive a confirmation email. Approval typically occurs within one business day; you may be notified via Teams or email when the licence is granted.
6. Once approved, return to the Company Portal, find the same app, and choose "Install". The portal will push the licence assignment to your device via Intune.
7. After installation completes, launch the application. Sign in with your Acme Global account if prompted; the licence should be recognised automatically.
8. If the application still shows an expiry or key-prompt error, sign out of the app, then sign back in, or restart the device and try again.

Service Desk Procedure: Assigning or Renewing a Licence

Agents in the Application Support group use the appropriate admin consoles to assign or renew licences. Verify the user's identity, check current licence status, and apply the needed change. Communicate the outcome to the user and guide them through re-authentication if required.

1. Open the ticket and confirm the user's name, employee ID, and the specific application requiring a licence.
2. Verify the user's Entra ID account is active and not locked out (check lockout status after 5 failed password attempts).
3. Open the relevant admin console:
- For Adobe products: Adobe Admin Console (https://admin.adobe.com).
- For Microsoft 365 apps: Microsoft 365 admin center (https://admin.microsoft.com).
- For other line-of-business apps: the vendor-specific management portal linked from the Company Portal.
4. Search for the user by email address and locate their current licence assignments.
5. If the licence shows "Expired" or "Not Assigned", select the user and click "Assign licence" (or "Renew licence" if an existing entitlement is available). For requests needing manager approval, forward the request to the designated approver and note the ticket with the approval reference.
6. After assigning, wait a few minutes for the change to propagate via Intune; you can force a sync by instructing the user to open Company Portal and sync policies.
7. Notify the user via Teams or email that the licence has been assigned, and ask them to:
1. Sign out of the application.
2. Sign back in using their Acme Global credentials.
3. Verify that the expiry or key-prompt message no longer appears.
8. Close the ticket with a resolution note detailing the licence assigned, the approval reference (if any), and confirmation of successful activation.

Verification and Closure

After the licence assignment step, both the user and the agent should confirm that the software functions correctly with the full feature set. This verification prevents premature ticket closure and reduces repeat contacts.

1. Ask the user to launch the application and perform a basic task that requires a licensed feature (e.g., export a PDF in Adobe Acrobat, create a new team in Microsoft Teams).
2. Confirm that no licence-related warnings or prompts appear.
3. If the user reports continued issues, collect any error codes, screenshots, and logs, then proceed to the escalation path.
4. Once verified, document the outcome in the ticket, set the status to "Resolved", and add relevant keywords for future searchability.

When to escalate

Escalate to the Identity & Access Management (IAM) team if the licence cannot be assigned because the user's Entra ID object is missing, disabled, or subject to conditional access blocks that prevent licence synchronization. Also escalate to Security Operations if the licence request triggers a suspicious activity alert (e.g., multiple rapid requests from different locations). When escalating, include:
- User's employee ID and email address.
- Exact error messages and timestamps.
- Screenshots of the licence-missing state in the admin console.
- Any relevant Conditional Access or MFA challenge logs.
- The ticket number and a summary of steps already taken.

Keywords: licence request, software activation, Adobe licence, Microsoft 365 licence, Company Portal, Intune, Entra ID, license expired, product key prompt, self-service licence, approval workflow